



ELSEVIER

www.elsevier.com/locate/cities

doi:10.1016/j.cities.2008.08.001

Cities 25 (2008) 370–382

CITIES

The image of the creative city: Some reflections on urban branding in Turin

Alberto Vanolo *

Dipartimento Interateneo Territorio, Politecnico e Università di Torino, Viale Mattioli 39, 10125 – Torino, Italy

Received 27 November 2007; received in revised form 22 July 2008; accepted 2 August 2008

Available online 27 September 2008

City-marketing and place-branding strategies today often stress ideas and stereotypes of culture and creativity to promote attractive urban images. The aim of this paper is to empirically analyze how the creative city is celebrated and displayed in the case of Turin (Torino), Italy. This case study represents a typical example of an industrial town, trying to promote new urban representations at an international level, and celebrating ideas of a cultural, post-industrial economy through campaigns of urban branding. This paper presents some reflections on the branding policies of the Italian city and, through the review of a sample of promotional materials and policy documents, it tries to determine to what degree Turin's branding represents ideas of creativity.

© 2008 Elsevier Ltd. All rights reserved.

Keywords: Creative city, urban image, place branding, Turin

Introduction

The popularity of the works of authors such as Florida (2002) and Landry and Bianchini (1995) has given a particular emphasis to the idea of the “creative city”. The core theoretical arguments at the basis of the “creative city approach” have been often criticized (for example, in terms of elitism, incongruent data, ambiguous implications in terms of policy: see, for example Peck (2005) and Scott (2006)), but in any case, creativity has become a major keyword in city-planning and urban-marketing policies around the world. In its simplest formulation, the main idea is that capitalist development today has moved to a new distinctive phase, in which the driving force of the economy is not simply technological or organizational, but human. “The creative class” (a vague category, including basically those engaged in knowledge-intensive works whose function is to “create meaningful new forms”, such as artists, scientists, analysts, business managers, opinion makers: Florida, 2003, p. 8) is today the “dominant class in the society” (Florida, 2002, p. ix), as it refers to the core of economic growth in developed countries. Moreover, such creative professionals are not

simply motivated by material rewards (salaries), but want to live in “quality”, “creative”, “tolerant” and “exciting” places. Therefore, according to such a framework, a key question for urban planning refers to the possibility of promoting creative environments and “cool city” images (Peck, 2005) in order to attract these professionals.

Assuming a critical position towards Florida's accounts, the aim of this paper is not to critically deconstruct the intrinsic theoretical and practical problems of creativity policies, but to discuss how ideas of the creative city are celebrated and displayed in the specific case of Turin (Torino), Italy. Basically, the fundamental question is whether Turin, in terms of urban branding materials and policies, is really sketching the image of a creative city in its attempt to escape its traditional image of a “one company town”. The thesis supported here is that image building in Turin is quite partial and different from the ideal one described by Florida, showing indirectly that a certain “Fordist culture” (or anti-Fordist) is still “in the air” in the field of the promotional and cultural policies of the city.

With this perspective in mind, the first part of the paper starts by presenting some theoretical insights on the concepts of urban branding and creativity. Then, the case of Turin, a city rebuilding a new image for itself in opposition to the old one centered on its automotive industrial past, will be briefly discussed. The third part will present

*Tel.: +39 011 5647445; fax: +39 011 5647499; e-mail: vanolo@econ.unito.it

some results from an empirical analysis carried out on promotional materials. Finally, some reflections will emphasize the partial nature of image building in the framework of creativity in Turin.

Urban branding and creativity

Despite the great number of different approaches involved in the study of the *image of a city*, which may range from environmental psychology to semantics, or from urban design to geography, an obvious common ground is the fact that the concept must be understood *metaphorically*. The image of a city, in the sense of the general meaning and idea of a place, is formed not only by visual images, but also by many other elements. Contributions to the study of urban images (and of the *sense of place* in general) highlight aspects relating to the *symbols* embodied in the material components of the city (roads, monuments, and buildings) as well as to many immaterial components such as the habits, routines, institutions, and organizations regulating the life of the inhabitants, and in addition to discourses about the city, stereotypes concerning the attitudes of the inhabitants, and descriptions from tourist guides, movies, slogans, and local-marketing campaigns (see among others Shields (1991)). This symbolic construction of the image of the city is usually analyzed from two different perspectives: the *internal image*, that perceived and reproduced by the local actors of the city (those identifying their geographical identities with that particular place: Lalli (1992)), and the *external image*, the perception and representation of the city by (and for) people and organizations more or less extraneous to local life and symbols. External ones are often particularly vague, abstract, and simplistic; for example, it is common to associate positive and negative values with unexplored or unfamiliar cities. Such images are important because they make it possible for us to organize information, formulate generalizations and expectations, and guide our actions (Shields, 1991; Entrikin, 1990) such as the choices made by tourists and investors. This is basically the reason behind the recent interest of many cities in *branding* (Kavaratzis and Ashworth, 2005): the construction of positive and charming images is a fundamental tool for attracting global flows of tourism and investments to promote local development (Gold and Ward, 1994). Florida (2002), who has affirmed that the *creative class* is attracted by *cool* cities (more on this later), fits implicitly into this theoretical framework. Of course, building up a competitive creative economy does not only mean attracting creative flows (firstly, creative professionals are certainly not a class unto themselves because of the lack of internal coherence), but it certainly implies the creation and representation of environments perceived as suitable for creative industries, both by city users and external actors.

Such considerations are important for post-industrial cities: one of their challenges is for example to make places attractive to specific target audiences, such as artistic communities, with their preference for vibrant artistic networks, a climate of support for arts, and a good and affordable quality of life (Gertler, 2004). This implies

the celebration of “new” post-Fordist urban identities, economies, life-styles, forms of work and consumption (Scott, 2000; Kneale and Dwyer, 2008). In line with this argument, one of Florida’s key argument is that the advanced capitalist world is living a revolution (equal in impact to the transformations of the 19th century) leading to a “new economy” characterized less by its dependence on labour input and raw materials, instead posing centrality on human *creativity*, intended as the capability to generate new solutions and ideas (concerning different definitions of creativity see, for example, Santagata (2005)). Such an idea is not new, as testified by widely diffused social and economic literature concerning the centrality of human capital in urban growth (for example, in terms of educated and skilled workforce: Glaeser (2004)). But, at the same time, the idea that particular “bohemian” and “creative” communities are the driving force in the new economy is arguable and simplistic, as testified by a number of statistical analyses (Glaeser, 2004; Peck, 2005). Moreover, Florida’s “creative city” policies, aimed basically at the construction of desirable environments for the “creative class” and the display of “creative images” of the city, often resolves in banal elitist selective policies, including real estate speculative development, gentrification, the enhancement of specific neighborhoods, for example through landmarks designed by famous architectural stars (Peck, 2005). But what exactly does attracting the “creatives” mean? In terms of promotional policies and urban branding, it may be considered as a set of practices of selective “story telling” (Sandercock, 2003) aimed at trying to manage what sort of understanding and impression potential visitors, investors or even inhabitants might get. Of course, branding is not constructing *tabula rasa* narratives; rather, it epitomizes a long articulation and framing process that must have a certain basis in the local identity and debates. Patently fake urban brands are destined to low credibility; the branding process must create evocative narratives with a strong spatial referent. One of the main arguments in this paper, concerning the case of Turin, is that a rooted industrial identity biases the development “new economy” and “creative” visions of the city: for example, how is it possible to talk about Turin without making reference to manufacturing specialization? Urban branding policies that do not take account of strong identity referents (the automobile industry, in the case of Turin) imply specific political perspectives and issues of credibility. They involve, for example, questions of rights: who has the prerogative to define urban identities, and who “lives the brand”? What are the political consequences of building up the image of a “creative city”? This is particularly important considering that brands can operate as a “legitimate vocabulary” for justifying specific urban policies, for example, in the case of creativity, in order to justify the transformation and gentrification of particular areas in order to attract the “creatives” (Peck, 2005).

Secondly, one problem is that it is not easy to detect what kind of urban images may be attractive and sustainable, especially considering the variability of fashions and stereotypes. For example during the 1990s, urban policy-makers commonly believed that global flows were attracted towards places associated with high technology.

Numerous cities developed specific labels and slogans combining comprehensive approaches to urban planning with the objective of developing information cities (Hepworth, 1990), such as Osaka (*intelligent city*), Barcelona (*telematics city*), Amsterdam (*information city*), and Manchester (*wired city*). The quest for the promotion of images linked to high technology seemed to be a panacea for many different urban problems, offering everything from the reversal of industrial decline to the promotion of social cohesion, from enhanced competitiveness to improved mechanisms of governance. This general attraction towards high technology encouraged promotion of such images even in places without specific technological vocations, and some authors introduced ironic expressions such as *high-tech fantasies* (Massey et al., 1992) or *technodream* (Dobers, 2003). In fact, urban policies of image development and city-marketing are basically cheap, and many towns fell into the trap of *serial reproduction* of promotional policies—to use the expression introduced by Harvey (1989) in the framework of his “entrepreneurial city” thesis—and saw their message disappear in the crowd of similar urban images in the marketplace (Jessop, 1998). This peril is evident in the field of “creative cities”: in recent years, concepts of high technology and stereotypical images of scientists, computers, etc. have been often replaced by the celebration of *cultural and creative industries* (Evans, 2003). Of course, this is just a general trend, and many exceptions can be found. Technology is evidently still appealing, and no urban-marketing campaign ever misses an opportunity to celebrate high-technology research, but cultural industries are quickly gaining special attention. This is probably connected to the fact that capitalism itself is moving into a phase in which the cultural forms and meanings of its outputs are becoming critical and dominant elements of productive strategy, and in which the realm of urban culture as a whole is more and more subject to commoditization (Scott, 2000; Hannigan, 2003; Evans, 2003). This topic becomes critically important for the urban economy. Firstly, cities are nodes of the production of culture, experimentation, art, and creativity in general (Zukin, 1995; Scott, 2000). Secondly, in cultural production industries, the relation between the cultural attributes of places and the qualitative aspects of the final outputs is often evident, as in the case of Hollywood movies, for example, or in many “Third Italy” industrial districts: place, culture, and economy are symbiotic, particularly in some key cities (Scott, 2000). This is an important topic for businesses and economic actors in general in both the manufacturing and service economies; the more the specific cultural and economic identities of cities make their presence known on the landscape, the more they can exploit monopoly powers of place, i.e., place-specific process and product configurations which enhance their competitive advantage (Power and Scott, 2004). In this sense, Molotch (1996, p. 229) stated that “favorable images create entry barriers for products from competing places”. One major problem refers to the abovementioned issue of the “crowding” of similar images: in a world where plenty of cities promote nearly identical “Florida-oriented” urban branding policies, their competitive advantage is ephemeral. Of course, it should not be thought that policies supporting urban

creativity are based only on the construction of images; in fact, such policies include many interventions (from physical planning to the organization of events) aimed at improving people’s lived experience of cities, supporting a holistic view of the urban social and economic fabric, and enhancing an urban milieu capable of generating *ideas*. However, in the eyes of urban promoters (and in the logic of this paper), the question is how to represent and build urban images connected to these ideas, i.e., the culturally oriented, socially attractive, and creative city. Specific labels, symbols, and communicative stereotypes have to be created and must circulate at the international level.

The work of Florida (2002, 2003), besides the critiques mentioned earlier, set a standard in this field, contributing to diffuse a widespread common rhetoric among urban promoters¹: not just technology, but multiculturalism, tolerance, the presence of various and diverse cultural stimuli, socially and culturally “open” social environments, rich in possibilities and opportunities for interaction, where a talented person can easily become part of the social fabric in a relatively short time (the *outsider* can quickly become *insider*; “getting into the loop”, to use the words of Storper and Venables (2004)), represent key elements in developing such an image. By looking at the international literature, the Florida arguments may be specified and better explained, identifying many key visual and non-visual elements widely used in order to nurture stereotyped images of the creative cities. The following scheme, built on the basis of bibliographic researches, will be used in the latter part of the paper as a metric in order to evaluate the cultural shifts in Turin’s urban branding. It is certainly not exhaustive, and subjectively includes elements of different relevance and importance, but it is useful in the way it presents a wide classification of “creative arguments and images”, as testified by the recurrence of such images in many promotional products in European cities:

- the “buzz”, i.e. scenes with people, and particularly of people meeting and chatting (see, in addition to Florida’s work, Storper and Venables (2004));
- variety and difference, with special attention to situations of multi-ethnicity, multiculturalism, and tolerance (Landry and Bianchini, 1995);
- a local art scene, including both “high” and more “popular” forms of art (Zukin (1995));
- night life, including both fancy restaurants and venues which attract young and trendy people (also called *playscapes*; Chatterton and Hollands (2002));
- public spaces, particularly natural environments and parks, together with facilities for outdoor sports (Cybriwsky, 1999) and landmark buildings (Temelova, 2007);
- opportunities for high-quality education for both young people and professionals, who are widely considered as an essential element of urban competitiveness (Stead, 2003).

¹ Also in the case of Turin, Florida has been explicitly quoted by a number of local policy makers.

- events, particularly *mega-events* (Hall, 1992; Hiller, 2000): large demonstrations, concerts, sports events, and cultural exhibitions have the *hypnotic* power to attract and concentrate, in the same time and in the same place, the attention of millions of people from all over the world (this is the *urban spectacle* discussed by Landry and Bianchini). This strong communicative power can be used in urban discourse to spread ideas of transformation, regeneration, and success, and not just for an external audience: cultural events may add life to city streets, giving citizens renewed pride in their home city (Richards and Wilson, 2004).

Introducing Turin and its branding policies

Turin is a northwestern Italian city, with a population in 2007 of about 900,000 inhabitants in the municipality, and 1.5 million people in the whole metropolitan area. It is the capital of the Piedmont region (4.3 million inhabitants), and the fourth Italian city in terms of population.

Turin is a central urban node in Italian economy (8.4% of national income was produced in the Piedmont region in 2007), particularly in the past. The city used to be known worldwide as an industrial town, the Italian capital of the automobile, because of the headquarters of FIAT, the automobile manufacturer—and curiously many urban studies have compared the profile of Turin with that of Detroit (Amari, 1980). Just to give some rough data on the role of FIAT in the economic life of Turin: statistics estimate that in 24% of families in the city, at least one person works for that company (Osservatorio del Nord Ovest, 2003). Despite the general stagnation of the automobile sector, local social and welfare figures are relatively good: the unemployment rate in 2007 has been 4.2% in the whole Piedmont region, against a national mean value of 6.1%; the percentage of young people (below 19) with at least primary education level is 99.4%, above the Italian mean value of 98% (Regione Piemonte, 2008). Immigration flows are significant (5.8% of the regional population refers to foreign residents, particularly from Romania), but integration process are not particularly problematic in the city with respect to other Italian cities: for example, marriages between Italians and foreigners are quite high (9.5% in the Piedmont Region; Italian mean value 7.0%). In this perspective, it has to be noticed that one diffuse idea concerning Turin refers to a high capability of social integration (Guala, 2000): productivism culture, Catholic religion, Socialism and Communism lived together in the last century, producing conflicts but not fundamentalisms (with the exception of Fascism, considered anyway “too weak in Turin” by Mussolini himself). This integration has been largely conveyed through mass work and an “industrial culture” celebrating self-discipline and the pride of the specialized worker. Industry regulated times in everyday life and in familiar behaviors, supporting high social standardization, but also low deviance: in other words, industrial work represented a fundamental parameter in defining social identities. It is not surprising, therefore, that the image of Turin is particularly tied to industry: it is not only the main external oversimplified idea about Turin, because of the obvious centrality of this economic

sector, but it is also somehow part of the city’s identity. The main stereotypes about the inhabitants, historical events (the first Italian working-class strikes and movements, as studied by Gramsci), economic specializations, and urban landscapes definitely tie the image of Turin to industrialism. For example, the opinion is widely held that the development of FIAT in Turin was closely tied to the city’s particular social environment, rooted in hierarchical and military organizations during the historical period of the Savoy dynasty. This is not to say that this is the “real” or “unique” face of the city, but this image is still strong, even if the economic base and the urban landscape have certainly changed gradually over time (particularly with the growing crisis in the automobile sector), becoming more and more differentiated and oriented towards cultural industries, for example in the field of high-quality food and wine (connected to the growth of some rural areas in the surroundings, such as *Langhe*: Santagata, 2002). This image inertia is confirmed and even strengthened by the fact that the city has been widely used in Italian movies, up to recent times, as a favorite setting for presenting situations of social tension, poor worker and immigrant environments, political activism and terrorism, and lack of opportunities for young people.²

The footprints of FIAT on the city are even wider: according to Revelli (1989), the whole physical development has been functional to the centrality of the company, with a chaotic growth consequent to the massive immigration of workers from different parts of the country, particularly in the 1950s and 1960s. Two landmarks testify to this industrial image. The first is *Lingotto*, the main factory from 1922 to 1982, a huge building incorporating ideas of rationalism and Taylorism (it was inspired by a visit to Detroit Ford factory), now converted to service functions (offices, hotels, congress spaces, shopping malls and a multiplex cinema), often portrayed in promotional brochures in order to support discourses concerning transition from industrialism to technology and service economy (Figure 1). The second one is *Mirafiori*, an immense productive area (about 1 million square meters) opened in 1936, actually largely unutilized and at the center of urban debates about how to use such an impressive area inside the city.

As in many other one company towns in and outside of Europe, the general crisis of the Fordist factory from the late 1970s has been dramatic. A particularly symbolic moment in the case of Turin has been the so-called “march of the 40,000”, in 1980, when both working class and white collar labourers demonstrated together in a massive strike, against the layoff of 23,000 workers (for a temporary period of 3 years). The demonstration did not succeed (the workers were effectively dismissed), but it left a severe wound in the social fabric of the city, laying the foundation for a debate on the future of the city, one that had to consider development directions other than FIAT. The economic destiny of FIAT is still open and unclear; in general, perceptions of crisis and recovery alternated

² Examples include *Torino nera* (Lizzani, 1972), *La ragazza di via Millelire* (Serra, 1980), *Portami via* (Tavarelli, 1994), *La seconda volta* (Calopresti, 1994), *Tutti giù per terra* (Ferrario, 1997), *Preferisco il rumore del mare* (Calopresti, 1999).



Figure 1 The renewed Lingotto (ex-Fiat factory). *Source:* Brochure “Always on the move”, Turin City Hall, 2006.

throughout the following years, stressing or alleviating a diffused sense of urgency in promoting non-industrial activities. Probably, the history of urban branding in Turin may be read as a history of progressive emancipation from FIAT. But, despite these tendencies, Turin has not yet lived a full post-Fordist transition. In the Province, employment in manufacturing has been 34.9% in 2006 (the highest Italian figure among metropolitan provinces), a quota similar to that of ten years earlier (36.4% in 1996). The service sector is growing quite slowly (Comitato Rota, 2008): manufacturing is still fundamental to the economic identity of the city, despite a general perception that manufacturing is synonymous of mono-specialization and crisis (Vanolo, 2004).

Concerning the issue of branding in Turin, it is necessary to emphasize that the promotion of the image of the city is a particularly new phenomenon. During the 1980s and early 1990s, a few questions about the image of Turin emerged from debates promoted by important local cultural institutions (Fondazione Agnelli, Ires Piemonte, Fondazione San Paolo), but not from the urban government. It is worth mentioning that among the hypothetical images for the future elaborated in the past (and currently forgotten), are those of *MITO* (an idea of strong functional integration with Milan along a 130 km axis), *GEMITO* (the same, but including Genoa), *Mechatronic land* (a region of mechanic and electronic expertise—and not just automobile productions), and *Turin Technocity* (stressing ideas of ICT, as in many other European cities in the 1990s).³ Two impor-

tant dimensions of these branding exercises have to be emphasized.

First is the informal nature of these branding attempts. Being voluntarily developed by cultural actors, they lack any sort of legitimization from the inhabitants, stressing the problem of the “authorization of a particular image” discussed by Short and Kim (1999). But, at the same time, these attempts stress the urgency for a branding and visioning policy.

Secondly, these attempts share one common denominator: the attempt to promote something different from FIAT. During the 1980s, such images (*MITO*, *GEMITO*, *Mechatronic land*, etc.) emphasized other manufacturing vocations for the city, while during the late 1990s, and particularly after a difficult industrial crisis in 1996, a massive refusal of manufacturing identities spread in the city.⁴ During the 1990s, salvaging ideas of hypothetical “new technology” specializations circulated: this can be confirmed by looking, for example, at a Motorola advertisement produced after the company’s decision in 1999 to establish a new R&D center in Turin (Figure 2). The Motorola logo (curiously similar to Batman’s logo, standing over the dark-industrial “Gotham city”) stands high over the city, recognizable by the outline of its main landmark (the *Mole Antonelliana*; see also Figure 6), while the text below suggests “Motorola gives wings to Turin”. This is quite meaningful, conveying the perception held at the end of 1990s that ICTs were the only hope to escape from the city’s industrial legacy.

³ For a discussion of these urban images see Fondazione Agnelli (1984), Rolfo (1993), Ires Piemonte (1994), and De Rossi and Durbiano (2006).

⁴ Even popular sentiments have progressively changed with the latest generations of workers: employment in FIAT is no longer generally seen as prestigious as it was in the 1950s (Bocca, 2002).



Figure 2 Motorola in Turin. Source: <http://www.itp-agency.org> (consulted March 2008).

The urgency to promote the image of Turin emerged, in fact, in the late 1990s (and particularly after the 1996 crisis) with the building up of some public-private institutions:

- ITP (Invest in Turin and Piedmont), a regional agency born in 1997 in order to attract investments and to help external enterprises to locate in the local area. ITP was born thanks to the contribution of various public and private organizations (above all, the municipality of Turin, Piedmont region, the local chamber of commerce). In 2006, it was reorganized. It merged its activities with those of the IMA (Regional Institute for agro-food marketing) and was renamed *Piemonte Agency for Investments, Export and Tourism*;
- three local tourism agencies (named ATL 1, 2 and 3), public-private consortiums created in 1997, each one specialized in the promotion of a certain part of the territory of the Province of Turin. Since 2006, the three agencies have been merged into one, called *Turismo Torino e Provincia*.
- Some organizations working in specific thematic fields, and particularly Turin Convention Bureau (born in 2000 with the aim of attracting and organizing fairs and exhibitions) and Turin Film Commission (born in 2000 in order to attract movie sets by providing various facilities).

But, even more, the first strategic plan of the city, called *Torino Internazionale*, approved in 2000 after 2 years of work, marked a dramatic step in the urgency of city branding. The elaboration of the plan has been organized by the homonymous association, originally including 60

partners (now 120) among whom the major of Turin and of the other municipalities of the area, other public bodies, academies, cultural foundations, private enterprises. The *Torino Internazionale* plan has been elaborated through three steps: firstly, academies and research bodies were asked to diagnose Turin's situation; then, thematic working groups, including representatives of civil society, worked on the definition of strategic lines and concrete actions, as well as on improving networks of co-operation or information between operators. The proposals from the working groups have then been refined gradually on the basis of debates with a scientific committee and representatives of the city council, and finally in 2000 it was approved, detecting six strategic lines and 84 concrete actions, with indications for the resources to be mobilized and the time involved in realizing it. The strategic plan had three general objectives: firstly (as testified by its name) to promote internationalization, but also to develop an organizational capacity for the city by collectively building a shared vision of its future, and to state this shared vision through a plurality of concrete operations in various sectors, many of them financed through Objective 2 European Structural Funds.⁵ But promoting tourism and debating about shared visions rapidly led Turin to question how to integrate itself into the global context after a century of FIAT, during which the city's

⁵ It is worth mentioning that, in 1995, the new *City Master plan* had been approved. It has promoted physical transformations of the city, and particularly the ongoing *spina* project, a major redraw for the city, including regeneration plans and the burying of many railway tracks.



Figure 3 Example of a promotional banner. *Source:* Photo by Claudio Pallard.

physical, social and economic development was determined by the vehicle manufacturer's growth rate and strategies. The unpredictability of FIAT's strategies and the possibility that some of its functions will be relocated has required local actors to develop strategies and images testifying economic conversion or diversification (Pinson, 2002). This direction was further confirmed in the second edition of the plan, published in 2006, where it is clear that the shared vision for the future of the metropolitan area consists of becoming "a knowledge society" (Torino Internazionale, 2006).

Finally, the Winter Olympic Games presented the opportunity to undertake a massive image-building activity. In terms of visitors, the city hosted about 1.1 million tourists in 2006: basically flows increased significantly during 2006, and then decreased in the following period, showing anyway a positive trend with respect to pre-Olympic years (Comitato Rota, 2008). But, even if tourism increases have not been really massive, the Olympic boost has been generally perceived as important for tourism (thanks to a massive celebration of the Olympic event for the city in media and political discourses) and fears of post-event slumps diffused quickly, highlighting the necessity to continuously promote major events for the city: just to name a few attempts, the 2006 World Fencing Championships, the Chess Olympics in 2007, or the Design Capital in 2008. In the field of branding, the Olympic challenge pushed the city to draw up a specific *communication plan*,

managed by an *ad hoc* office called the *central communication service*, with the aim of "shaping a new visual identity for the city" and renewing their marketing materials (Martina, 2006). Even if promotional materials are also produced by other institutions such as the Piedmont region, the central communication service is the heart of promotional activity in the city today, fully institutionalizing the process of image building, previously (as discussed) quite informal and dispersed through many local actors. Its work consists of producing marketing materials, both directly and by means of external advertising agencies, and circulating them through national and international media. The municipality of Turin provided the main guidelines through the *communication plan*, but the central service is largely autonomous in its activity.

The emerging attempt to build up a branding process is apparent, for example, in the choice to refer to the city, not as *Turin*, but as *Torino*, regardless of language (Owen, 2006), and to associate it frequently with the slogan "always on the move" (proposed by the famous advertising agency Armando Testa) to emphasize that something is *changing*. This message (and, from 2006, also "passion lives here" and "Torino is more and more beautiful", placing explicit emphasis on an affective marketing rhetoric) was widely promoted through many media, right before the Olympic Games, with the installation of more than 7000 banners and posters and 3000 flags throughout the city (Figure 3).

Table 1 Construction of a creative brand

General ideas	Components		
	Visual and physical elements	Slogans and narrations	Events
<i>Buzz</i>	Pictures of crowded places, bars, and clubs (<i>Figure 4</i>)	Various marketing materials; [. . .] <i>a thousand opportunities for seeing friends, getting together, dancing, staying out late</i>	No specific events
<i>Art</i>	Visual marketing materials, new art installations (<i>Luci d'artista</i>), enhancement and promotion of the old baroque heritage	Various marketing materials; <i>Torino is a city of art de vivre and fun, an intelligent and worldly cultural capital</i>	Several art events (music, cinema, theater, visual arts, etc.)
<i>Diversity</i>	Visual materials showing people from different parts in the world, particularly linked to tourism and specific events like <i>Terra madre</i> (<i>Figure 5</i>)	No specific references to diversity or tolerance	Events: <i>Terra madre</i> , world meeting of food communities; <i>From Sodom to Hollywood</i> , Turin International Gay and Lesbian Film Festival
<i>Nightlife</i>	Several pictures displaying night “movida,” clubs, and crowded places	Various marketing materials; <i>Torino [. . .] is also shows, cabaret, literary cafes, street festivals, dance, clubs</i>	Events: <i>Notti bianche</i> (all-night-long parties across the city)
<i>Public spaces</i>	Images of public spaces, for example parks, but also creation and promotion of new public spaces (<i>Atrium, Palaisozaki</i>)	References to gathering spaces; <i>Piazza Castello, Piazza San Carlo, Piazza Vittorio Veneto and Piazza Bodoni have become splendid pedestrian gathering places</i>	Events: <i>Traffic</i> , summer music festivals in urban parks
<i>Higher education</i>	No specific images	References to universities and polytechnic schools	<i>Night of the researchers</i> event, offering a closeup of the world of research; <i>Universiadi 2007</i> international sport Olympics.
<i>Other (commodities: food and wine)</i>	Many visual marketing materials	Various marketing materials; <i>Enjoying good food and drink is undoubtedly an important part of Torino's culture</i>	Many events: <i>CioccolaTo, Capital of books</i>



Figure 4 The buzz in Turin. *Source:* Brochure “Turin c’est l’apéritif”, Turin City Hall, 2007.



Figure 5 Stereotyping diversity. *Source:* Brochure “Passion Lives Here”, Turin City Hall, 2007.

Creativity in Turin

The aim of this study is not to determine whether Turin has changed into a creative city, but rather to focus on the construction of its image, determining to what degree the “new” Torino image—the Olympic and post-Olympic one—lies within the realm of creativity. To do this, the general taxonomies presented in the previous paragraphs and synthesized in *Table 1* have been used as a general

framework for the classification of various initiatives and promotional campaigns proposed by the city. The scheme distinguishes between the topical content of the messages (raws) and the kind of media used to convey the message, i.e. materials and initiatives emphasizing the physical and visual dimensions (for example, photographs or images of specific landmarks), the narrative dimension (speeches, slogans), and the construction of specific references to creativity and culture in Turin through events.

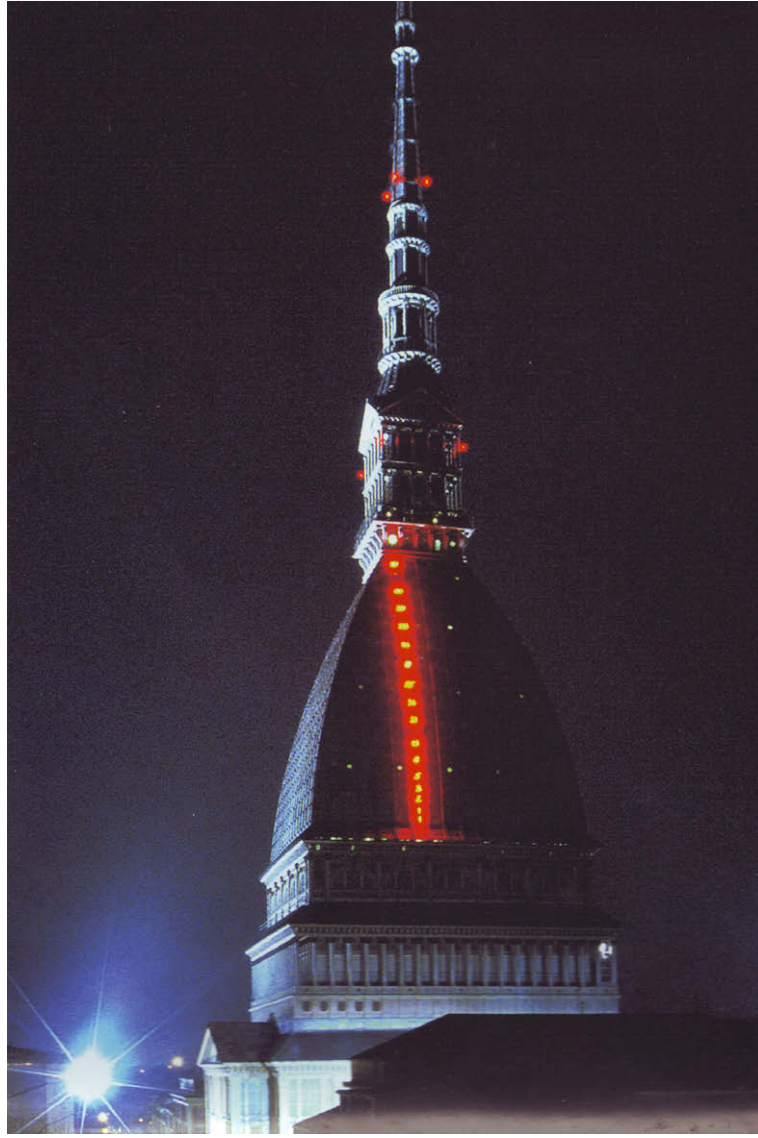


Figure 6 “Luci d’artista” (art lights). Source: Brochure “Art”, Turin City Hall, 2007.

More specifically, the classification effort addresses marketing materials provided by the central communication service of the city of Turin, materials produced between 2006 and 2007, including 18 advertising brochures, the promotional DVD *Passion lives here*, the photo CD provided to foreign news agencies to help them compile articles on the city, and the official websites.⁶

At first glance, almost all the cells in *Table 1* are filled, which is evidence of a certain diversification of messages and a visible attention to creative branding. This is not surprising if we consider that the new (i.e. the second) strategic plan of the Metropolitan Area (*Torino Internazionale*, 2006) proposes, among its 12 axes of intervention, the promotion of creativity. However, in the marketing

materials, there is no mention of the word “creativity,” and an interview with the head of the communication unit confirmed that it is not one of the keywords of the recent promotional campaigns, despite the explicit reference to the theme in the Second Strategic Plan. Image building has been supported by physical infrastructures (at a huge cost⁷), policies, and events, both in a culturally direct manner and in a quasi-cultural one. The first category includes the construction of new landmark structures designed by prestigious international architects (for example, *Atrium*, by Giugiaro Architettura, or *Palaisozaki*, by Arata Isozaki), creation of (and improvements to) local muse-

⁶ <http://www.torinoplus.it>; <http://www.turismotorino.org>; <http://www.torinopiemonte.it>. Details on the methodology for the analysis of brochures are also discussed in Vanolo (2008).

⁷ The transformation directly connected to the Olympic games reached a total amount slightly greater than 1 billion euros, including infrastructure elements and improvements to the local airport, highways, and railways (434 million euros), the Olympic and media villages (278 million), sporting-event sites such as the hockey stadium (222 million), and health and security measures (anti-doping center, helicopter security) (40 million). See Catalano and Arresta (2006).

ums (the most important institutions, in terms of visitor flows, are the Cinema and Egyptian museums, together with the Venaria Reale), support of local art foundations, installation of artistic elements in different parts of the city (for example, light sculptures—*luci d'artista*, Figure 6—light games, and illumination systems designed by artists, or Mario Mertz's installations), and the organization of events (art expositions, the “book capital” event, the World Design Capital 2008). These elements, which were quite disconnected from the sports events, strongly nurtured the cultural dimension of the city in its traditional meaning. This has increased the attractiveness of the city, as confirmed by slightly increasing tourist flows. On the other hand, many policies labeled as “cultural”, such as *CiocolatoTo*, which is aimed at the promotion and diffusion of high-quality chocolate (a typical gourmet indulgence of Turin, recently “rediscovered” largely for tourist purposes), mainly support local manufacturing by commoditizing culture, i.e., transforming and packaging culture into easy-to-consume products (for example, chocolates, wines, books, and event tickets), with the promotion of the city occurring as a side effect. These operations are usually carried out in a sound way in Turin, with great emphasis on the celebration of traditions (such as that of chocolate production), on quality, on respect for the environment and, specifically, on creativity, even if it is not so evident the connection between chocolate and creativity. In any case, such endeavors appear to be explicit ways of associating a product with a place (or *co-branding*), developing the capabilities both of *selling the city* and of *selling the product*, and creating new symbols for both the geographical location and the commodity under the aegis of the celebration of culture, which certainly helps in selling both. This particular emphasis on the celebration of the city through (or together with) the celebration of the commodities and consumption reflects a certain Fordist attitude (or post-Fordist, but anyway intended as a heritage and a reaction to a Fordist perspective; Kneale and Dwyer, 2008): this becomes evident considering that Table 1 includes both “real” events, attracting external flows (of visitors, for example) and other more “symbolic”, strongly self-celebrative of the image of the city (as probably in the case of the “Book Capital” event).

Alternatively, it is important to notice that, in Table 1, the contribution of “diversity” is the weakest, because there is no intrinsic association between human variety and culture. Pictures portraying multiethnic and multicultural situations are sometimes displayed, but mainly in a context of social well-being, presenting convincing peaceful situations, while such images are rarely used in support of discussions of creativity and culture. In a similar way, the dimension of higher education is somewhat marginal to the cultural promotion of the city, apart from some references to the presence of a functional academic system.

Generally speaking, the transformation of the city in recent years, and specifically of Turin's urban policies, is clearly evident and completely positive. This judgment is basically subjective—objective data and surveys are still missing, apart from those reporting small increases in tourist flows—but it is apparent that this emphasis on urban cultural policies has rendered the city more beautiful

and buzzing⁸ in the eyes of the inhabitants: in other words, the internal image of the city is improving, as emphasized by recent surveys.⁹ The celebration of images of “the buzz”, in particular, happens through the representation of particular landmark areas of the city: this is the case of *Murazzi*, the waterfront area on the Po River (with many clubs for youth nightlife) and *Quadrilatero*, a central area recently gentrified by “creatives” (above all by artist and trendy young communities). Such spaces assume an important symbolic role in the celebration of the idea of a lively city, basically by presenting stereotyped image of an urban *playscape* where to consume nighttime entertainment.

Similar images of Turin are quite surprising if we consider that, a few years ago, most of the marketing materials and scientific studies about Turin were focused on the construction of images of the *land of mechatronics* (Rolfo, 1993) and the *telecommunications pole* (Ires Piemonte, 1994), with little attention paid not only to entertainment, but also to the realm of creativity and culture. Particularly, in recent years the technological aspect of the city is still discussed and celebrated in marketing materials and policy orientations (for example in the Strategic Plan), but the case of Turin seems to confirm a progressive transition from the mere celebration of technological innovation to something more (and not something alternative¹⁰), which is the combination of the competitive edge in technology with culture in its broader meaning, including foggy ideas of creativity, based above all on the celebration of some “creative local productions” (chocolate, books) and post-Fordist forms of consumption (events, entertainment). The main question in terms of urban branding is: where is the spatial referent, giving credibility to the celebration of “creativity” in the city? Moreover, if we consider that every representations of the urban (and geographical representation in general, being a “culturally learned way of looking at places”: Barnes and Duncan, 1992) carries on a specific “political unconscious” it is plausible to suppose that the partial result of Turin in developing a certain image of creativity (the stereotyped one, epitomized by the table presented in paragraph 1) reflects a difficult positioning of the local identity (brand) in the post-Fordist, “creative cities” global arena of competition.

Concluding remarks

In the perspective of this analysis, it seems that the creativity debate has gained some ground among urban pro-

⁸ *Torino è sempre + bella* (more and more beautiful) is a slogan presented in the official website of the City: www.torinoplus.it. The sentence, “Turin is buzzing,” is presented in a website text.

⁹ Crivello (2006). After all, the International Olympic Committee often emphasizes that an Olympic bid must be driven forward by the inhabitants of the city, and the level of popular support for hosting the event has become a criterion for evaluating the candidates.

¹⁰ *Technology*, of course, was also celebrated during the Olympic event. Examples concerns the use (and celebration) of environmentally friendly energy sources and video technologies for mobile phones, or the highly symbolic new automatic subway system, driven by a computer, without the need for human operators.

motors in Turin. Certainly, urban creativity is not at all a revolutionary approach towards urban policies; rather, it often involves a “cheap” group of heterogeneous actions (from supporting the local art scene to the organization of public events) that can easily create a public consensus (being basically risk-zero), even in the face of possible negative feedback and outcomes that are difficult to quantify (Peck, 2005).

In the realm of urban branding, such a critical position is also plausible. Urban images of creativity may appear to be nothing new, but just a new slogan picking up old stereotyped images concerning the urban milieu. In fact, images celebrating the buzz, the serendipity, the street life, and the cultural milieu of cities were widely prevalent in urban-marketing materials years ago, before the current creative fashion, because these elements refer, in fact, to the core of urban life (Short and Kim, 1999; Landry, 2006). Anyhow, it can be argued that probably new and increased attention is being given to creativity as an urban asset. The high-tech focus discussed earlier has lost some ground with respect to social images of creativity, together with an explosion of urban events linked to these topics. Many cities are now investing heavily in cultural industries and cultural images, with creativity as an important umbrella concept, even if the urban images and stereotypes are the same as yesterday's. The urban milieu, and particularly images of public spaces, crowded squares, and cultural events still remains the basis of the attractiveness of cities, both in the eyes of the creative class and for the rest of us. Anyway, not every city displays ideas of creativity using exactly the same set of stereotypes, as testified by the case of Turin, where certain dimensions in the celebration of creativity are missing. What is certainly new in Turin (and in the planning landscape in general) is this growing interest in the analysis and marketing of many dimensions of urban attractiveness which were until recently often neglected, and a certain broadening of the promotional messages provided by the city. Cultural image building, in the case of the former “capital of the automotive industry”, seems to be particularly dynamic, but in the framework of creativity, still incomplete, because the emphasis seems to be placed, on the one hand, on “high culture” and events, and on the other hand, on the promotion of ready-to-consume culture, as in the case of gourmet foods. Moreover, little attention has been given in the realm of urban images to the importance of diversity, tolerance, multiculturalism, and education—the “human capital” dimension of creativity discussed as central in the current economic scenario by Florida (2003). Moreover, this orientation seems to reproduce a certain elitist vision of the creative class: on the one hand, there are images targeting the high-culture audience (classical art lovers, for example), and on the other hand, a popular commoditization of culture. To put it briefly, the creative class is implicitly considered as something to attract because of its potential to consume, i.e., because of its capability to increase the demand for consumer goods, and not for its intrinsic innovative potential and its capability to improve the quality of

a location, as stressed by the sociologist Florida and others like him.¹¹ A suggestive interpretation of such a consideration may refer to old Fordist based visions of the economy—an economy where the city produces and tries to sell “goods” to different audiences, including now the creative audience. In other word, it seems to persist in Turin a Fordist heritage which is still challenging to deal with: despite a progressive, formal emancipation from Fordist industrial visions and from Fiat, it seems to persist a deeply Fordist culture in the promotion of a cultural face for the city.

Acknowledgements

The author would like to thank Serena Vicari, Francesca Governa and the RTN UrbEurope “Creative cities” research group.

References

- Amari, G (1980) *Torino come Detroit: capitale dell'automobile, 1895–1940*. Cappelli, Bologna.
- Barnes, T J and Duncan, J S (1992) Introduction. Writing worlds. In *Writing Worlds. Discourse, Text & Metaphor in the Representation of Landscape*, T J Barnes and J S Duncan (eds.), pp. 1–17. Routledge, London.
- Bocca, G (2002). FIAT. Quando per i torinesi era la mamma-padrone”. *La Repubblica*, October 10th. <http://www.larepubblica.it> [consulted March 2008].
- Catalano, S and Arresta, D (2006) La trasformazione materiale e immateriale del territorio. Lo stato dell'arte a un anno dai giochi. In *Olimpiadi, oltre il 2006. Torino 2006: secondo rapporto sui giochi olimpici*, P Bondonio, E Dansero and A Mela (eds.), pp. 65–102. Carocci, Roma.
- Chatterton, P and Hollands, R (2002) Theorising urban playscapes: producing, regulating and consuming youthful nightlife city spaces. *Urban Studies* 39(1), 95–116.
- Comitato Rota (2008) *Solista e solitaria*. Guerini, Torino.
- Crivello, S (2006) Torino, verso una nuova immagine della città? In *Olimpiadi, oltre il 2006*, P Bondonio, E Dansero and A Mela (eds.), pp. 295–312. Carocci, Roma.
- Cybrirsky, R (1999) Changing patterns of urban public space. Observations and assessments from the Tokyo and New York metropolitan areas. *Cities* 16(4), 223–231.
- De Rossi, A and Durbiano, G (2006) *Torino 1980–2011. Le trasformazioni e le sue immagini*. Allemandi & C, Torino.
- Dobers, P (2003) Image of Stockholm as an IT city: emerging urban entrepreneurship. In *New Movements in Entrepreneurship*, C Steyaert and D Hjorth (eds.), pp. 200–217. Edward Elgar, Aldershot.
- Entrikin, N (1990). *The Betwenness of Place. Towards a Geography of Modernity*. Macmillian, Basingstoke.
- Evans, G (2003) Hard-branding the cultural city - from Prado to Prada. *International Journal of Urban and Regional Research* 27(2), 417–440.
- Florida, R (2002) *The Rise of the Creative Class. And How It's Transforming Work, Leisure, Community, and Everyday Life*. Basic Books, New York.
- Florida, R (2003) Cities and the creative class. *City & Community* 2(1), 3–19.

¹¹ Recently (November 2007), a new welfare-oriented policy was proposed by the Piedmont Region to increase tolerance towards immigration. This is not an external image for marketing promotion (and therefore falls outside the scope of this research), but an internal policy for the inhabitants, directed towards objectives of social cohesion. In this context, the persistence of economic-oriented visions is surprising; instead of humanitarian or social discussions, the main slogans are “a wealth of difference” and “foreign entrepreneurs matter.”

- Fondazione Agnelli (1984) *TecnoCity*. Fondazione Agnelli, Torino.
- Gertler, M S (2004) Creative cities: what are they for, how do they work, and how do we build them? Canadian Policy Research Network, Background paper F/48, Ottawa.
- Glaeser, E (2004) Review of Richard Florida's the rise of the creative class. *Regional Sciences and Urban Economics* 35(5), 593–596.
- Gold, J R and Ward, S V (1994) Introduction. In *Place Promotion. The Use of Publicity and Marketing to Sell Towns and Regions*, S V Ward and J R Gold (eds.), pp. 1–17. John Wiley & Sons, Chichester.
- Guala, C (2000) Integrazione sociale. In *Torino. Il grande libro della Città*, B Garbarotta, S Ortona, R Rocchia and G Tesio (eds.), pp. 732–734. La Stampa, Torino.
- Hall, C M (1992) *Hallmark Tourist Events: Impacts, Management and Planning*. Belhaven, London.
- Hannigan, J (2003) Symposium on branding, the entertainment economy and urban place building: introduction. *International Journal of Urban and Regional Research*, 27(2), 352–360.
- Harvey, D (1989) *The Condition of Postmodernity*. Blackwell, Oxford.
- Hepworth, M E (1990) Planning for the information city: the challenge and response. *Urban Studies* 27(4), 537–558.
- Hiller, H (2000) Mega-events, urban boosterism and growth strategies: an analysis of the objectives and legitimations of the Cape Town 2004 Olympic bid. *International Journal of Urban and Regional Research* 24(2), 439–458.
- Ires Piemonte (1994) *Reti. Telecomunicazioni in Piemonte*. Rosenberg & Sellier, Torino.
- Jessop, B (1998) The narrative of enterprise and the enterprise of narrative: place marketing and the entrepreneurial city. In *The Entrepreneurial City: Geographies of Politics, Regime, and Representation*, T Hall and P Hubbard (eds.), pp. 77–99. Wiley, New York.
- Kavaratzis, M and Ashworth, G J (2005) City branding: an effective assertion of identity or a transitory marketing trick? *Tijdschrift voor Economische en Sociale Geografie* 96(5), 506–514.
- Kneale, J and Dwyer, C (2008) Consumption. In *A Companion to Cultural Geography*, J Duncan, N Johnson and R Schein (eds.), pp. 298–315. Blackwell, Oxford.
- Lalli, M (1992) Urban related identity: theory, measurement and empirical findings. *Journal of Environmental Psychology* 12, 285–303.
- Landry, C and Bianchini, F (1995) *The Creative City*. Demos, London.
- Landry, C (2006) *The Art of City Making*. Earthscan, London.
- Martina, A (2006) *Comunicare la città. Il caso di Torino olimpica*. Paravia-Mondadori, Torino.
- Massey, D, Quintas, P and Wield, D (1992) *High Tech Fantasies. Science Parks in Society, Science and Space*. Routledge, London.
- Molotch, H (1996) LA as design product: how art works in a regional economy. In *The City: Los Angeles and Urban Theory at the End of the Twentieth Century*, A J Scott and E W Soja (eds.), pp. 225–275. University of California Press, Los Angeles.
- Osservatorio del Nord Ovest (2003), La percezione della crisi FIAT; www.nordovest.org.
- Owen J (2006) From 'Turin' to 'Torino': Olympics put new name on the map". National Geographic News. <<http://news.nationalgeographic.com>>.
- Peck, J (2005) Struggling with the creative class. *International Journal of Urban and Regional Research* 29(4), 740–770.
- Pinson, G (2002) Political government and governance: strategic planning and the reshaping of political capacity in Turin. *International Journal of Urban and Regional Research* 26(3), 477–493.
- Power, D and Scott, A J (2004) A prelude to cultural industries and the production of culture. In *Cultural Industries and the Production of Culture*, D Power and A J Scott (eds.), pp. 3–15. Routledge, London.
- Revelli, M (1989) *Lavorare in Fiat*. Garzanti, Milano.
- Richards, G and Wilson, J (2004) The impact of cultural events on city image: Rotterdam, Cultural Capital of Europe 2001. *Urban Studies* 41(10), 1931–1951.
- Rolfo, S (1993) *The Italian Machine Tool Industry*. Ceris, Torino.
- Sandercock, L (2003) *Cosmopolis II. Mongrel Cities for the 21st Century*. Continuum, London.
- Santagata, W (2002) Cultural districts, property rights and sustainable economic growth. *International Journal of Urban and Regional Research* 26(1), 9–23.
- Santagata, W (2005) Creativity, fashion and market behaviour. In *Cultural Industries and the Production of Culture*, D Power and A J Scott (eds.), pp. 192–203. Routledge, London.
- Scott, A J (2000) *The Cultural Economy of Cities*. Sage, London.
- Scott, A J (2006) Creative cities: conceptual issues and policy questions. *Journal of Urban Affairs* 28(1), 1–17.
- Shields, R (1991) *Places on the Margin. Alternative Geographies of Modernity*. Routledge, London.
- Short, J R and Kim, Y-H (1999) *Globalization and the City*. Pearson, Harlow.
- Stead, D (2003) Is urban living becoming more attractive? *Local Environment* 8(5), 559–565.
- Storper, M and Venables, A J (2004) Buzz: face-to-face contact and the urban economy. *Journal of Economic Geography* 4(4), 351–370.
- Temelova, J (2007) Flagship developments and the physical upgrading of the post-socialist inner city: the Golden Angel project in Prague. *Geografiska Annaler B* 89(2), 169–181.
- Torino Internazionale (2000) Torino Internazionale. Il piano strategico della città, Associazione Torino Internazionale, Torino.
- Torino Internazionale (2006) Secondo piano strategico dell'area metropolitana di Torino, Associazione Torino Internazionale, Torino.
- Vanolo A (2004) The external images of Helsinki and Turin: representing high technology and industry vocation. Working Paper Research and Training Network Urban Europe, n.8. <<http://www.urban-europe.net>>.
- Vanolo, A (2008) Internationalization in the Helsinki Metropolitan Area: images, discourses and metaphors. *European Planning Studies* 16(2), 229–252.
- Zukin, S (1995) *The Cultures of Cities*. Blackwell, Oxford.